

Europe [after the Asian Championships] because of the mental toll. Gurindervir too lost form ahead of the University Games and was forced to sit out," Hillier added.

Hillier said he has pointed out several areas of discomfort preventing elite athletes from performing at their best. Most remain unaddressed. **One such problem has been the daunting schedules during national events, which do not take into account recovery time.** "Manikanta had three races on the same day [at the Inter-State]. First at 7:30 am, and then back by 5:30 pm for the semifinal and then the final. How can you expect an athlete to perform?" he asked.

Martin Owens, Head Coach at the Odisha Reliance Foundation High Performance Centre, under whom Animesh trains, highlighted the lack of clarity in turning national events into trials for major competitions. "Most federations lay down the qualifying criteria at the beginning of the year. Part of the problem here is that they're playing it on the fly all the time. There's always a meet to qualify for a meet, and a trial to qualify for another trial," he said.

Hillier also called out the lack of consistency in decision-making after rules were bent to allow lower-level athletes into the Inter-State roster. He expressed dismay at elite athletes having to run three rounds at national events due to the bloated participant list, which could result in overuse injuries.

"Athletes must be put first. In India, I see knee, thigh and hip flexor injuries. You don't get these injuries in athletics. There are too many high-intensity races to be able to sustain yourself," he added. Owens echoed Hillier's thoughts. He suggested that a preliminary round be held, as in the Worlds and Olympics, before ranked athletes enter. "I'm not saying all championships should just be geared to the elite and that lower-level shouldn't compete against the elite. Only when they do will they get inspired. But at the same time elite athletes shouldn't suffer," Owens said.

A major reason for the improvement of the short-distance runners has been the constant competition among themselves. Both coaches believe athlete-friendly events and a closely competitive talent pool will be key in helping athletes climb up the ladder. "Success breeds success. Once somebody breaks the record, the other person says, 'Why can't I do it?' That's the culture we need. Then the sub-10s, sub-20s and sub-45s will happen," Hillier said.

"Everyone needs to speak the same language — the coaches, the media, the federation. That's how we're going to make this happen," he added.

Start young, start right



Indian athletics' significant step forward over the last decade has been restricted to improving the performances of the country's top athletes rather than identifying more talent, reckoned Owens.

Neeraj Chopra's unprecedented international success has set the stage for greater interest in javelin throw. But role models alone cannot spur an athletics revolution, he said.

"There are plenty of competitions in India at the top end, but not enough at the grassroots. Kids need to compete," Owens said.

"It doesn't have to be electronic timing or synthetic tracks. It can just be in a field. We see plenty of kids play cricket but not everybody plays at Chepauk, do they? You need kids who want to get out there and be the next Manikanta Hoblidhar, Animesh Kujur or Tamil Arasu," he added.

Hillier also echoed Owens' sentiments, adding that "talent needs to find the system and not the other way round."

"There is an obsession with trying to find a story. 'We went to a village, where there's a six-year-old throwing a stick, and 20 years later he becomes another Neeraj.' It never works like that. You run competitions everywhere. That's your talent ID," he said.

"We are not teaching people the right things. You've got to teach movement skills, and then, by default, people will stick their heads up and say, 'I'm talented,'" Hillier added.

Owens and Hillier also bemoaned the lack of women's participation in athletics.

"Many athletes like Jyoti [Yarraj] and Rupal [Chaudhury] have been successful in spite of the system. These athletes had everything against them, yet somehow survived," Hillier said.

"It is very depressing that there are so many straight finals in the women's events. You cannot tell me that a population of 1.4 billion are all men. We need to encourage girls and women to do the sport, and that is vitally important," Owens remarked.

The coaches also cautioned against pushing young athletes too early into specialisation. Hillier explained a proposal he had put forward during his UK Athletics stint — a three-sport model for kids between seven and 13, where 50 per cent of the time is dedicated to athletics, followed by a two-sport model between 13 and 18.

The craving for early success is another issue plaguing the grassroots. Coaches are being judged on medals rather than on the improvement they bring about in athletes.

"Development coaches must be rewarded for getting athletes to move better. Instead, they're rewarded for medals. You don't have to be a high achiever at 16 or 17. Studies show there needs to be some exposure at 13, but things don't really start happening until the 20s," Hillier said.